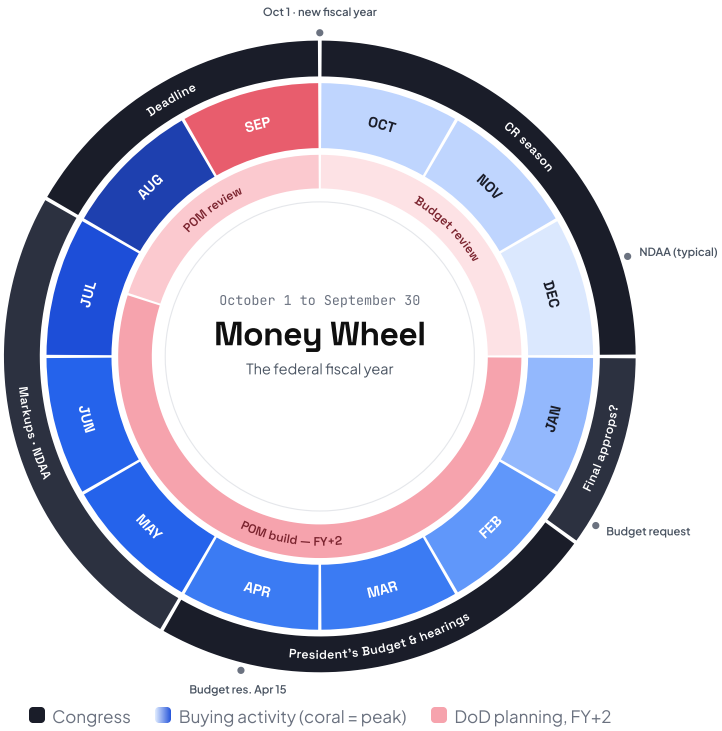
The Federal Money Wheel

Federal money runs on a clock most founders can't see. Three calendars, one wheel.



HOW TO READ IT

- **Outer ring, Congress:** CR season, final appropriations, the President's Budget, markups and the NDAA, then the September 30 deadline.
- **Middle ring, buyers:** darker means more contracting. September is typically the biggest month of the year.
- **Inner ring, DoD planning:** the budget for two years out is built January to July. Not in the plan means no line of your own.

DATES THAT MOVE MONEY

Oct 1	New fiscal year, usually under a CR
Dec	NDAA typically signed
1st Mon of Feb	President's Budget due (often late)
Apr 15	Budget resolution target
Jul 1	Q4 begins: the buying surge
Sep 30	One-year money expires; funding deadline

MONTH BY MONTH

MONTH	THE MOOD	YOUR MOVE	COMMON MISTAKE
Oct	New year, old money	Book meetings, not deals. Program offices have time to talk and nothing to spend.	Putting Q1 revenue in your forecast from a buyer who is on a CR.
Nov	Talk season	Turn October's meetings into a one-page problem statement your champion can forward internally.	Mistaking a friendly meeting for a funded requirement.
Dec	Deadlines and dark weeks	Read the NDAA for new authorities, pilot programs and reports that name your space. Each one is a reason to call.	Treating a December verbal “yes” as booked when funds aren't released.
Jan	Doors start opening	This is the window to get into the budget two years out. Give your champion a sized, costed requirement.	Waiting for the RFP. By the time it's public, the requirement was written months ago.
Feb	The budget drops	Read the J-books. Find program lines where your capability fits and the funding is growing.	Pitching a capability without naming the budget line that pays for it.
Mar	Spend plans go live	Engage Hill staff where you have a district or state footprint. Requests close soon.	Skipping RFIs because they aren't a real opportunity yet.
Apr	Planning for September	Ask contracting officers what they plan to award in Q4 and on which vehicle, then get onto that vehicle.	Assuming you'll be eligible for an award without the right vehicle.
May	Markup season	A line of report language can legitimize a whole program. Work with your champion and the Hill.	Ignoring markups because they aren't law yet. Report language steers money anyway.
Jun	Get ready-to-award	Have a ready-to-award package: draft statement of work, pricing, vehicle, points of contact.	Arriving in August with a slide deck instead of a priced, award-ready package.
Jul	The surge begins	Be easy to buy. Quote fast and use whatever vehicle they already have.	Insisting on your own contract terms in a quarter when speed wins.
Aug	Peak workload	Help, don't burden. Offer the facts the contracting officer needs: market research answers, sole-source rationale, capability statements.	Missing the office's internal cutoff, which comes weeks before September 30.
Sep	Use it or lose it	Answer your phone on September 29.	Assuming a September yes carries into October if the paperwork isn't done.